leading to much controversy during the Emergency years. Rahul later told an aide in an unguarded moment, ‘I am not my uncle. He tried to destroy the Youth Congress, I want to build it.’

A few months after taking over, Rahul met some of us at his residence (once again, off the record, of course!). Through the meeting, he spoke passionately about his desire to revamp the student bodies of the Congress, how he wanted to ‘democratize’ the organizations by ushering in new faces. He spoke of holding free and fair elections to these bodies, of organizing ‘talent hunts’ where necessary, of questionnaires that were being prepared to identify the right people for specific tasks. ‘We will transform the Congress party bottom-up in a manner that will be truly revolutionary!’ he said, with almost missionary zeal. For the old-timers amongst us, it was a near-rewind to Rajiv Gandhi’s famous speech in the 1985 Congress centenary session in Mumbai when he had vowed to rid the party of ‘power brokers’.

He also reflected on his other big idea—the need to bridge the divide between ‘Bharat’ and ‘India’, between the ‘poor’ and the ‘rich’. I had heard him speak on the ‘two Indias’ at a public rally during the Congress plenary session in November 2007; now he was giving us a detailed exposition on his social and economic world view. ‘You cannot have one India that travels on a bullet train and another that takes a bullock cart,’ he said in a tone of controlled aggression. I couldn’t decide whether he was astoundingly platitudinous or earnestly sincere, whether the lectures on the Indian predicament were his own eureka moments, or whether in fact he had charted out a long-term agenda of inclusive growth for a more compassionate India.

I must confess emerging from that meeting with a sense that we had perhaps underestimated Rahul Gandhi. Here was a young man from India’s most durable political family promising to end the dynasty cult and open up the closed shop that Indian politics had become. His economic thoughts were more dodgy—they appeared almost a straight lift from some 1970s thesis, echoing a certain old-world socialist viewpoint that was completely at odds with the massive changes taking place in post-liberalization India.